Kannada for over four decades now, and the 12 stories in *Heart Lamp* have been chosen from this corpus.

"Usually, research students and teachers want a single edition of my Kannada work, so my publisher released an omnibus edition with over 50 stories," says Mushtaq. "In 2022, a journalist interviewed me about the issue of hijab in Karnataka educational institutions and it was during this process that I was introduced to Deepa (Bhasthi).... She read this omnibus edition and chose the ones that impressed her the most. I didn't have any role in that selection process, but I suggested she add one-two more."

As Bhasthi explains, once the selection process was over, the next challenge was rendering Mushtaq's unique style of Kannada into English. A conscious choice made by the translator-writer duo was to forgo italics, glossaries et cetera that "explain" Kannada words. Instead, the translation itself makes the context clear.

"She uses a polyglot's version of Kannada wherein there are words and sounds from the other languages spoken in the region," says Bhasthi. "Hindi, Urdu, Dakhani, et cetera, and this is a very normal thing for both of us, as well as for so many South Indians. Working with writers like Banu Mushtaq makes you push yourself as a translator. It makes you challenge notions of 'classical' and 'colloquial' in a language."

It's tough to pick a favourite among the 12 stories in *Heart Lamp*, but personally, I found 'Black Cobra' and 'Be a Woman Once, Oh Lord!" deeply moving. The women in these stories realise that the dice is loaded against them, and whatever respite they get is usually symbolic. In 'Black Cobra', a beleaguered young mother, Aashraf, mounts a public protest against her husband's abrupt abandonment of her and her daughter Munni, with disastrous results. The 2004 National Award-winning Kannada film *Hasina*, directed by Girish Kasaravalli, is based on this story.

MUSHTAQ AND BHASTHI CHOSE TO FORGO ITALICS AND GLOSSARIES THAT 'EXPLAIN' KANNADA WORDS IN THE TRANSLATION

'Be a Woman Once, Oh Lord!' is a critique of the role played by organised religion in the 'domestic enslavement' of women. As the title suggests, the hapless female protagonist here directly addresses God, claiming that God cannot fully understand her plight until he takes on a female form.

"In 2000, I was working as a lawyer and travelling to a taluka court by bus," recalls Mushtaq. "And I saw a woman, a beggar, who was singing a devotional Kannada film song. She had a marvellous voice and she was referring to herself as 'daasi' (servant) for her prabhu (God). I was very affected by her singing and her feelings of devotion and when I was writing this story ('Be a Woman Once, Oh Lord!'), those two words, prabhu and daasi, were on my mind."

While announcing Mushtaq and Bhasthi's place on the International Booker shortlist, the judges had praised the "immense emotional and moral weight" wielded by the stories in *Heart Lamp*. Rightly so, for these stories command the reader's undivided attention. And as is the case for top-shelf literature in any language, by the time the last page is turned, it is the reader who is forced to confront the prospect of change, not least within themselves. ■

—Aditya Mani Jha

tively) have grown up in Old Delhi in nearby-but-segregated lanes. When the college-educated young women snag accounting jobs in the same Noida firm circa 2007, their families brace themselves for "corrupting influences". Soon, Seema falls in love with her bigoted Gujarati employer's son Mohan.

Notably, Seema, with her Hindu-sounding name, is encouraged by Madhu to hide her Muslimness and, sure enough, the young woman abandons her usual hijab and smiles politely at her employer Kantibhai's Islamophobic quips. This section is perhaps the most entertaining, where Patel balances narrative tension and plot resolution expertly. He is also very good at the exposition-heavy, history-imbued passages where we learn about the beginnings of Noida and the rise of consumerist culture in Delhi/ NCR.

PATEL IS GOOD AT **HISTORY-IMBUED PASSAGES** ABOUT THE BEGINNINGS OF NOIDA AND THE RISE OF CONSUMERIST CULTURE IN DELHI/ NCR

Where Patel falls short is dialogue. He's very good at descriptive sentences, but his idea of dialogue is neither wholly realistic nor convincingly dramatic. For example, when Seema tragically loses her father, Madhu's mother consoles her with the Hindi words, "*Bhagwaan ki kripaa rahe tum par beti* (May God be merciful to you, child)." I have no doubt that there are people who sound like 70s' Bollywood mothers. But I wager they are the exception, not the rule.

That quibble apart, *Across the River* is largely successful in capturing the unique vibe of the late 2000s—recession in the air, people trapped in exploitative jobs, political upheavals across the world. Against this backdrop, the aspirations of Seema and Madhu, whether romantic or professional, acquire a special kind of poignance. *Across the River* handles weighty issues like communal strife and patriarchy with an efficient, low-fuss method. ■

—Aditya Mani Jha